era. And in that context, analogies from the past certainly offer some guidance.

The two figures most popularly associated with diplomacy in Indian traditions are unquestionably Hanuman in the Ramayana and Sri Krishna in the Mahabharata. One is perceived as an exemplary embodiment of service, who performs his duties undaunted by any obstacles. The other is regarded more as a strategist and counsellor, a source of wisdom in difficult moments. Each has his criticality in the given context, and Hanuman is at his best when confronted with uncertainty and tough odds. The process of a nation's rise is not unlike the arduous campaigns which embedded both of them so deeply in our consciousness. In fact, it is more than a campaign; it is an endless exercise of expanding prospects. And like Hanuman, it requires true believers and problem solvers who are at it 24x7.

As Lord Rama's emissary to Lanka, Hanuman's cleverness in gaining critical intelligence about an adversary, and even access to the confined queen Sita, were crucial developments. In addition, he used his mistreatment by the *rakshasa*s, who set his tail on fire, to do them immeasurable damage by burning the city. But he also developed key insights about Ravana, his temperament and his advisers. Equally vital is his judgement of Ravana's brother Vibheeshana, who alone stood up for him when he was brought before the court. It is Hanuman's certification of his integrity that encouraged Rama later to welcome Vibheeshana after his defection from Ravana. Typically, people tend to think of diplomacy just as mediation. But in reality, there is so much more to it, including the ability to read competitors, allies and the landscape correctly.

Hanuman is also noted for his persistence, a quality he demonstrated when his fellow monkeys were inclined to give up on their search for Queen Sita. His ability to improvise and solve problems is equally in evidence when he lifts an entire mountain in order to bring back a single life-saving plant. At the end of the war, he is sent on a delicate mission to inform Bharata of the outcome and to assess whether he would really welcome Lord Rama's return to Ayodhya. Each of these attributes are today the prized quality of a successful diplomat.

A different illustration of the complexities inherent in diplomacy is provided by the monkey-prince Angada. He, too, was sent by Rama to Ravana's court in Lanka and cleverly played to his strengths. In his case, that specifically was his leg, which could not be moved once firmly planted on the ground. By making it a challenge, he embarrassed those who tried unsuccessfully to shift his limb. Finally, he humiliated Ravana when the latter tried to reach out for it and dropped his crown that Angada then picked up and threw it back to Lord Rama. As an envoy, he not only resists blandishments proffered by Ravana but improvises to make his points effectively. Denied a seat that is due to him, he is said to have made a chair for himself by elongating his tail and placing himself on par with the demon-king before him. After all, mind games are a key element of diplomacy.

A very different kind of skill was displayed by his mother Tara, the wife of the monkey-king Vali, who was earlier killed by Lord Rama. In the cases of Hanuman and Angada, they were dealing with Ravana, a haughty and irreconcilable adversary. Their mission was to both obtain information and leave psychological scars that would affect the morale of the other side. In the case of Tara, she was confronted with the anger of her current king Sugriva's allies Rama and Lakshmana. Sugriva had failed to deliver on his promise to locate Sita once he ascended the throne after Vali. It was then that Tara was sent to parley with Lakshmana as he approached Kishkinda, twanging his bowstring to signal his aggressive intentions. Her tactics were astute, and she initially appeased Lakshmana by admitting to Sugriva's fickleness. Having done so, she underlined his devotion to Rama and